

What is source analysis?

Everything we know about the past, we know from something that survived. A stone. A letter. A drawing. A number in a table.

Source analysis is what you do to turn one of those things into **evidence** — and how you work out how much to trust it.

START HERE

A source is not the same as the past

The past is gone. You cannot go and look at it.

What is left behind is a **source**: something that survived, by luck or because somebody kept it. A source is not the past itself. It is one thing that came out of it.

That matters, because every source was made by someone, for a reason, and leaves things out. A photograph is taken from one spot and not another. A letter is written to one person and not everyone. A stone tool tells you what it was used for and nothing at all about the name of the person who held it.

THE MOVE THAT MAKES IT ANALYSIS

Anyone can say what a source *shows*. Source analysis is saying what it **proves**, and how far.

Those are different sentences. "The stone has deep grooves in it" is what it shows. "The grooves are evidence that people ground food here, though they cannot tell us which plant" is what it proves, and where that proof stops.

Everything in this booklet is generated from the same file as the wall in your classroom, so the words here and the words there are the same words.

THE METHOD

Four questions, every time

Ask these of any source, in any subject. They are the same four the wall is built on — and the same four your work is marked against.

■ Origin, features & purpose

What is it, and who made it?

Say what kind of source it is, where it came from, and why someone made it.

This source is... It was made by... They made it because...

▲ Historical context

What was going on at the time?

Say what was happening around the source, and what the people in it believed or cared about.

At the time... The people who made it believed...

● Historical interpretations

What do people say it means?

People who study the past do not all agree. Say what the different explanations are, and what each one rests on.

Some argue... because... Others argue... because...

◆ Accuracy, usefulness & reliability

How much is it worth as evidence?

Say what the source is good for, what it cannot tell you, and how sure you are.

It is strong evidence for... but it cannot tell us... because...

You will not always answer all four in that order, and some sources give you much more of one than another. But if you have not asked all four, you have not finished.

WHAT A GOOD ONE LOOKS LIKE

How one stone becomes evidence

What does GS73 suggest about life at Madjedbebe in ancient Australia?

The ancient object is GS73, a broken piece of a sandstone grinding stone excavated at Madjedbebe, on Mirarr Country. The modern source is a set of photographs published by Hayes and her team in 2022. Their purpose was to record the wear and argue that people ground food there for a very long time. In ancient Australia, grinding allowed people to eat hard seeds and tough plants. It also shows they understood the resources around them. Hayes and her team interpret this as plant processing, because the stone carries deep grooves, microscopic polish and 41 starch grains. Other researchers question how old the layer really is. GS73 is very useful for studying how people prepared food, because its shape, its wear and its plant traces all agree, but it cannot tell us which plant was ground.

- Origin, features & purpose ▲ Historical context ● Historical interpretations
- ◆ Accuracy, usefulness & reliability

Notice how much of it is **not** marked. The plain words are the glue — they are what turns a list of facts into an argument. If every word were coloured, none of it would be evidence of anything.

MARK IT UP YOURSELF

Find the sentence that says what the source **cannot** tell us. Underline it. Then find the word that limits how certain the writer is being, and circle that.

Why each part counts

Each marked phrase on the page before is doing one specific job. Here is what each one proves.

■ **Origin, features & purpose** Separates the ancient object from the modern 2022 record, then identifies origin, features and why the figure was created.

▲ **Historical context** Outlines how grinding supported plant preparation and knowledge of local resources.

● **Historical interpretations** Describes the plant-processing interpretation and the separate challenge to the earliest date.

◆ **Accuracy, usefulness & reliability** Concludes that converging methods make plant processing useful evidence, then bounds the claim with two limits.

YOUR TURN

Write one of your own

Use a source your teacher gives you. One or two sentences per question is plenty — a good answer is short and exact, not long.

■ What is it, and who made it?

This source is... It was made by... They made it because...

▲ What was going on at the time?

At the time... The people who made it believed...

● What do people say it means?

Some argue... because... Others argue... because...

◆ How much is it worth as evidence?

It is strong evidence for... but it cannot tell us... because...

THE WORDS

Words you need

These are on the vocabulary hub in eighteen languages. Tap any of them in the online version to see your own.

archaeologist	Someone who studies the past by digging up what people left behind.
artefact	An object made or used by people in the past.
audience	The people something was made for.
bias	Leaning towards one side instead of being fair.
chronology	The order in which things happened.
context	What was going on around the source when it was made.
corroborate	To back something up with separate evidence.
evidence	The part of a source that proves something.
excavate	To dig something carefully out of the ground.
eyewitness	Someone who saw it happen with their own eyes.
hearsay	Something you were told, rather than saw yourself.
interpretation	What someone thinks a source means.
manuscript	A copy of a text written out by hand, before printing existed.
perspective	How something looks from one person's point of view.
primary source	A source made at the time by someone who was there.
purpose	The reason something was made.
reliable	Able to be trusted.
secondary source	A source made later by someone studying the past.
source	Something from the past that we use to find out what happened.
translation	A version of a text put into another language.

BUMPING IT UP

The same source, answered better

The wall shows one source answered at every level from Foundation to Year 10. Nothing in the source changes. What changes is what you do with it.

GRADE 5

GS73 is a stone source found at Madjedbebe. I can see deep grooves and shiny patches. It comes from ancient Australia and may have been used for grinding. Researchers disagree about exactly how old its soil layer is. The stone is useful for showing tool use, but it cannot tell us the user's...

YEAR 7

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YEAR 9

GS73 is material evidence, excavated from a recorded layer called Phase 2. Hayes and her team published photographs, microscope images and laboratory results together. They did this because one form of evidence alone would not convince a scientific audience. The study belongs to wider research into...

Read those three in order. The facts are the same. What grows is the number of separate things being held together in one sentence, and how carefully the claim is limited.

BEFORE YOU HAND IT IN

Check your own

- Have I said what the source **is**, and who made it, and why?
- Have I said what was going on at the time?
- Have I given more than one explanation, and what each rests on?
- Have I said what it is good evidence **for**, and what it cannot tell us?
- Have I used a limiting word — *may*, *suggests*, *although* — anywhere I am not certain?
- Is there plain writing between my quotes, doing the explaining?

THE ONE-SENTENCE VERSION

Say what it is, say what was going on, say what people argue about it, and say how far you would trust it.

Source: panels adapted from Figure 3 of Hayes, E. H. et al. (2022), “65,000-years of continuous grinding stone use at Madjedbebe, Northern Australia,” *Scientific Reports* 12, 11747, doi:10.1038/s41598-022-15174-x (open access, CC BY 4.0). Figure prepared by Elspeth H. Hayes. The dating comparison uses Clarkson et al. (2017) and Williams et al. (2021). The research was conducted with permission from the custodians of Madjedbebe, May Nango and Djaykuk Djandjomerr, and Mirarr Senior Traditional Owner Yvonne Margarula, with Gundjeihmi Aboriginal Corporation facilitating the work. Mirarr-related images and information were published for general educational purposes; no commercial use is authorised without prior Mirarr consent. See SOURCE-NOTICE.md.